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The Global Circulation of Skill and Capital – Pathways of Return Migration of Indian Entrepreneurs from the United States to India

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The phenomenon of return migration is ‘the great unwritten chapter in the history of migration’ (King, 2000: 7). Although migration to high-income OECD countries from poor developing nations has often been considered to be permanent up to now, in fact it has always had an element of impermanence, and more so at the present time because of the accelerating globalization of the world economy and the constant international migration of workers meeting the demands of emerging global markets. This means that migration in the present century often involves multiple migratory patterns, spread over a considerable period of time, that entail the flow of ideas, capital, attitudes and the skill sets of migrants themselves. As Faist (1997: 206) states, ‘leaving and returning may not be decisions taken only once [but] occur repeatedly over the life course of a mover’.

This chapter addresses this lacuna in contemporary migration literature. It examines the complexities of social, economic and political macro-structural factors that provide support to transnational Indian entrepreneurs for the necessary preparation in making decisions to return to India from the United States. The chapter focuses on how the dramatic shifts in Indian state policies since the 1980s, which created an enabling economic and political environment, resonated with personal aspirations and ambitions of Indian migrants to encourage them to return to their home country. It ascertains that the decision of return migration is inspired by multiple intentions and the anticipation of positive outcomes at a personal level.

Most literature relating to Indian migration to the United States has focused on the immigration and employment networks of highly skilled migrant Indian professionals and engineers in the United States and their occupational integration in the American economy (Bagchi, 2001; Saxenian, 2002, 2005; Chakravartty, 2006; Harvey 2008; Dossani 2012). The very few existing studies on Indian return migrants from the United States have dealt exclusively with technology entrepreneurs, and their overwhelming concern has been with transnational entrepreneurship between narrowly conceived regions in India and the United States, namely, Silicon Valley and Bangalore (Saxenian, 2008). My chapter aims to widen and diversify the conversation in the literature on Indian returnee entrepreneurs by incorporating many more urban locations in India that can now be called truly global, as well as by including the perspectives and experiences of returnee entrepreneurs in non-technology businesses, along with those in the technology sector. In addition, this chapter also dispels the myth, perpetuated by earlier studies, that return migration is associated with 'retirees' or with those migrants who have 'failed' in the host country for various reasons – failure to assimilate in the host country, expiration of work permits – and that both groups make little contribution to the development of their home societies, implying that those who succeed prefer to stay overseas (Maron and Connell, 2008). Contradicting this notion, this chapter shows that many contemporary highly skilled Indian migrants in the United States view movement between sending and receiving countries not in terms of losers and winners but as a global circulation of skill and labour, and this significantly influences their motivation, preparation for return, profile and return decisions (Mahroum, 2000). This concept of return/circular migration was further encouraged by the development of high-technology industries in India, such that the 'returnee entrepreneurs' began to perceive India as a place of equal if not greater promise (Wadhwa, 2012).

This chapter begins with a portrayal of Indian migrants in the United States, followed by a summary of remarkable transformations that have taken place in India since 1980. A review of the 'network' perspective in the context of return migration is presented, where I explain how strategic use of social and cultural capital brings about the formation of essential global networks and ties/linkages that enhance the preparation and decision-making process for return migration to India. Next, I explain the methods and data upon which this chapter is based. Following this introduction, I present findings that show how returnees' social class, age, life-course transitions, familial responsibilities and

nationalism shape return migration decisions. I conclude by summarizing the research findings and highlighting the essential contribution of 'networks' to global mobility among highly skilled migrants.

Indian migration to the United States

Contemporary migration from India to the United States began in the mid-1960s and has accelerated in the four subsequent decades. The revision of the US immigration laws in 1965 allowed for the first time the admittance of a large number of skilled professionals from India. Many highly trained Indian migrants took advantage of the VISA allocation preference given to 'priority workers; professionals with advanced degrees, or aliens of exceptional ability'. These 'persons of extra-ordinary ability' or 'outstanding researchers' were accused of playing a role in the 'brain drain' from India at that time. This movement of Indian immigrants corresponded to a significant gain for the United States in highly trained and skilled personnel (Portes and Rumbaut, 2006). Twenty-five years later, a further revision of immigration law in the Immigration Act of 1990 substantially increased the number of technical and specialty temporary workers arriving in the United States under the temporary H-1B visa programme, which has become the primary channel for the arrival of huge numbers of skilled professional Indian migrants in the past 20 years. It can be argued that the strategy of furthering the development of advanced capitalism through innovation and science and technology that has emerged in northern countries in the last decades lay behind the revision of immigration law in 1990. The evolution in capitalism had fuelled the attraction and retention of highly trained professionals from all over the world. To that end, the United States and other Western nations, including Germany, the United Kingdom, Denmark, Canada and Australia, have revised their immigration laws. This strategy relies on the actual international transfer and utilization of the human capital resources required to stay ahead in competition and the economic growth curve (Khadria, 2001; Mahroum, 2005; Portes and Rumbaut, 2006).

A great number of Indians also enter the United States as students desirous of American higher education. India has remained one of the leading countries of origin for international students in the United States (The Institute of International Education, 2012). Consequently, the major modes of entry of highly skilled Indian immigrants to the United States create a positive image for this ethnic group, which comprised 2.2 million adult Indian Americans in 2010, having a median age

of 37 years (PEW Research Center, 2012). They join the US labour market and benefit from the good character of the resident ethnic Indian community in the United States. The high labour force participation rate of Asian Indian migrants (69.6 per cent of those who were 16 or older in 2008–2010) contributes to a positive context of reception for Indians in the United States. The occupational profile of this ethnic group in the United States, with 67.9 per cent employed in professional and managerial occupations in 2008–2010, bears out the close association between high levels of education (78 per cent have a bachelors degree or higher) and their socio-economic location in American society (Allard, 2012).

Indian immigrants are likely to come from urban centres – which in the Indian context indicates a certain modernity, Western orientation and familiarity with the English language – and also from the middle and upper classes and castes and are typically trained in medicine, economics, nursing, engineering or management. The ambitious young people endowed with cultural, human and social capital are those that leave for the United States in an attempt to reduce ‘the gap between available salaries and work conditions in their own countries and those regarded there as acceptable for people with their education’ (Portes and Rumbaut, 2006: 18–19). This makes contemporary Indian migration a selective process.

Understanding return migration

Like emigration, return migration is inherently risky and life-changing. Often, migrants’ reasons for return are closely linked to those for departure. Return migration itself may be temporary; after returning home, migrants may move back to the host country or to a new, third country.

Under the neo-classical approach, which considers wage and employment differentials to be the key determinants of migration, return migration suggests that migrants failed abroad or received inadequate rewards for their human capital. However, as a significant share of international migrants from poorer nations – economic migrants, refugees and asylum seekers – return home or migrate to a third country even when the host country offers higher wages and better employment prospects, clearly no simple answer exists.

Departing from the neo-classical framework, which perceives migrants as concerned with maximizing their earnings and the length of their stay to achieve permanent residency and family reunification, the new economics of labour migration (NELM) perspective defines return migration as a ‘calculated strategy’ shaped by migrants’ household

needs. Migrants travel abroad until they succeed in providing their household with the income and financial liquidity they had hoped for (Cassarino, 2004). The skills and education acquired abroad are affected by the probability of return.

Despite their differences, these two perspectives illuminate migrants' motives and strategies for migrating, staying and returning home. As Cassarino (2004: 256) states, 'whether they are faced with market failures at home or with a need to compensate for wage differentials between their countries of origin and their areas of destination, migrants plan and try to respond to market uncertainties'. Jensen and Pedersen (2007) clearly substantiate this. Their research examined immigrants' incentives to leave or stay in Denmark and revealed that entry age, education, home country, family ties and labour market success influenced the decision to return, stay or move to a third country. When immigrants could acquire human capital faster in Denmark, or skills and types of human capital that simply were not available at home, their decision to return reflected their ability to re-enter their home country at a higher relative point in the wage distribution. They also found that immigrants from advanced countries were likely to leave, whereas those from developing nations tended to stay.

Adhering to the NELM approach, Maron and Connell (2008) found that Tongan migrants' motivation to return to their village of Nukunuku stemmed from their purchasing power and social standing upon their return. Return decisions, they maintain, are often governed by the accumulation of a target level of savings that would allow the migrants to enjoy a certain lifestyle back at home, where prices are often lower. Similarly, with a comprehensive data set covering return migration from Sweden to Germany, Greece, Italy and the United States during 1968–1996, Klinthall (2003) established that return is likely if migrants' earning potential increases due to their stay abroad or if the general wage levels shift in favour of their home country.

Nevertheless, Cassarino (2004) finds major shortcomings in both frameworks. First, each explains the migrant's behaviour solely in financial and economic terms, neglecting how remittances and skills are used in the home country. Second, neither mentions the home country's social, economic and political environment, implying that return is an isolated action. For example, the NELM framework analyses how migrants plan and reshape their return strategies and timing, but it does not look for explanations beyond the household or family.

To address these flaws, the structural approach examines the home country's social and institutional factors. In research on Italian returnees

from the United States, Cerase (1974) highlights the crucial role of contextual factors at home in making the return a success or a failure. Similarly, Alberts and Hazen (2005) examined international students' intentions to stay or return home. They established that professional advancement and opportunities strongly motivated students to stay in the United States, whereas personal and societal factors, such as a strong attachment to their home culture, their family ties and their network, significantly motivated them to return.

While the structuralist framework helps overcome the myopic view that only the individual migration experience affects return migration, it focuses primarily on how returnees' plans to innovate in their home countries are likely to conflict with established local power. Scant interest is given to the process of return migration. Further, as an analytical framework, it assumes negligible information and skills exchange between the host and home societies. Its major weakness is that it does not consider how the return migrant can acquire and deploy the skills necessary for successful re-entry. Hence, overcoming the NELM and structuralist viewpoints' failings requires us to think differently about return migration – that is, not as the end of a migration cycle but as an integral part of circular social and economic relationships and exchanges which bring about the movement of people (Cassarino, 2004).

The scholarship on transnationalism and social network analysis, which emphasizes the maintenance of regular and dynamic linkages between the home and host societies, explains how influential these linkages can be for return migration decisions. From the transnational perspective, the migrants' subjective perception of their homeland and their self-definition drive their decision to return. Al-Ali and Koser (2002) state that the social and economic network of transnational migrants extends across many societies and nations, and the main characteristic holding the members together is their common home country or shared background. Their shared ethnicity, kinship linkages, language and religious affiliation define the members' identity and in-group solidarity and dictate their transnational behaviour and practices. Consequently, this perspective departs from the structuralists' pessimistic outlook and focuses on the ease with which returnees fit into the home society at all levels, well equipped to take advantage of the 'identity characteristic' they attain overseas, while distinguishing themselves from the locals.

In many ways, the network theory's view is similar to that of the transnational perspective, with one major difference: the cross-border linkages or relationships are devoid of common attributes. This

difference broadens our understanding, allowing us to apply the complexity of return migration across an extremely heterogeneous group of return migrants. Further, network membership cannot be assumed, as networks are selectively organized based on shared interests and require the approval and support of other members, with a view to ensuring resource flow and the effectiveness and maintenance of cross-border linkages.

Network analysis focuses on interpersonal relationships per se, and on the composition of the networks, which consist of linkage configurations as well as a multiplicity of social structures. Accordingly, network analysis serves as a relevant theoretical framework to grasp the dialectic between individuals and structures in the context of initial migration and return (Gu, 2012). Here, I follow Gold's (2005) definition of a network approach, which

emphasizes that migration is embedded in a series of political, ethnic, familial, and communal relationships and environments, including some that cross borders. Through it, we see that migrating populations remain connected to more than one national context.... A network approach understands migration as a collective process shaped by both agency and structure.

This analytical framework helps us appreciate how resources, capital, knowledge, information, goods and ideas flow through particular configurations of social ties or bonds (Faist, 2000). It establishes a socio-historical perspective, showing the influence of previous migratory events on current and future ones. It reveals how migration systems linking particular countries in precise relationships are shaped through connections and ties developed from continuous human flows (Meyer, 2001), framing migration not as a one-way path but as a dynamic process (Mahroum, Eldridge and Daar, 2006).

Like interpersonal relationships, networks provide resources crucial to returnees' initiative and success once they return. Such resources lie embedded in social capital, defined as 'the ability of actors to secure benefits by virtue of membership in social networks or other social structures' (Portes, 1998). Social capital therefore is an intangible universal resource inherent in relationships and presents itself as information (potential or real) or linkages to other network members, who may be sources of support or control (Bashi, 2007). However, return migrants are not homogeneous – they include entrepreneur returnees, migrant students, refugees and asylum seekers, and highly skilled migrants – so

the context in which social capital is situated and the circumstances under which it is generated must be considered (Kadushin, 2004), as it is responsible for various motivations for return. Rogers (1984) states that broadening the return migration spectrum results in not only diverse return motivations but also various forms of resource mobilization depending on migrants' social locations and characteristics, including institutional, political and economic conditions in the home country, labour markets, the welfare system, the business and entrepreneurship sector, the time spent abroad, legal status, social class, gender, ethnicity and race, and sexual orientation (Gold, 2005: 260).

What follows is an explanation of the preparedness, motivation and decision-making process among Indian migrant entrepreneurs who have returned to India. I do this by analysing how social structures influenced returnees' access to networks and the resources they deliver, which played a decisive role in their actions.

Data sources and sample

The data presented in this chapter is drawn from multi-sited ethnographic field work and 42 in-depth interviews conducted in 2007 and 2011 with Indian migrant and returnee entrepreneurs in multiple urban centres in the United States and India. As Indian migrants are a widely dispersed population in the United States (Portes and Rumbaut, 2006), the best way to obtain a fairly representative sample of immigrant and returnee entrepreneurs from wide-ranging business sectors was to seek multiple data sources.

First, I gathered information on migrant and returnee entrepreneurs in both countries by extensively participating and volunteering in numerous community activities among Indian migrants for 3–4 years prior to 2007. I attended TiE (The Indus Entrepreneurs) chapter meetings in Chicago and Detroit and social gatherings for Hindu festivals such as Holi, Navratri, Diwali and so on. On all these occasions, I kept extensive notes of my observations. Second, I exhaustively used personal networks of family, kin and friends to gather information about transnational entrepreneurs residing in both countries. Third, beginning in 2003 I used public data sources on the web and the mailing lists of Indian professional and business associations to build a master roster of potential respondents' names, office addresses and type/sector of transnational business in the United States and India.

In India, I visited the office of NASSCOM¹ in New Delhi, where I had lengthy conversations with the secretary and officials of this premier

trade institution of the IT-BPO industries in India. Finally, to supplement the primary data from interviews, I used secondary data from the 2000 and 2010 US Decennial Census, the Department of Homeland Security's Office of Immigration Statistics (OIS) for 2010–2011, the American Community Survey report of 2010, World Bank documents, Government of India Reports, Pew Research Center and Migration Policy Institute research publications, newspapers and online articles to analyse transnational business trends among Indians in the United States and India.

The next step of the data collection process was to select suitable respondents from the master roster, which had information on more than one hundred entrepreneurs at the time of my initial fieldwork in 2007. In order to incorporate multiple perspectives into the analysis, I employed a stratified purposeful sampling strategy. I created a semi-structured interview schedule that contained open- and closed-ended questions (Legard, 2003) which focused on three major themes: (a) immigration and return migration (b) the societal or institutional structures that contributed towards respondents' cultural, human and social capital, and (c) the respondents' utilization of diverse networks. Follow-up questions were asked to encourage detailed description and in-depth interpretation. The language used in the interviews was English. The interviews, which ranged in duration from one to two hours, were recorded and transcribed verbatim. Names have been changed to protect identity.

The findings presented in this article are from two data sets, comprising 36 men and 6 women. The small number of women in the sample is due to the difficulties of recruiting women who had been full-time transnational entrepreneurs for more than five years. A major hurdle faced by several women entrepreneurs who had chosen to go back to salaried employment was the strain of balancing frequent foreign travel with family responsibilities. All subjects of this study were born in India and were owners and founders or partners in private transnational businesses for more than five to seven years.

Further, more than half (25 of 42, or 60 per cent) of the respondents were below the age of 50 or had migrated to the United States in the period 1980–1999, whereas 40 per cent (17 of 42) were above the age of 50 or had migrated to the United States between the years 1965 and 1979. One can infer that the imbalance in the ages of the respondents in this study is reflective of the demographic characteristics of the Indian population, where 75 per cent of the Indian population is below 35 years of age (Haub and Sharma, 2006). The two time frames were selected to

capture the influence of the macroeconomic policy changes in India since it broke from its socialistic past, particularly in assessing respondents' motivation for migration to the United States and return to India.

India since the 1980s

The death of the formidable Prime Minister Indira Gandhi in 1984 marked the end of socialist-leaning policies in India, replaced by an embrace of 'pro-business' development strategies. The Indian state gradually became highly interventionist² (Kohli, 2007) by giving precedence to economic growth as a national goal. But, unlike many of the high-growth economies in East Asia, the Indian economy has grown within the framework of a democracy. Its meteoric development was also accompanied by major changes in foreign policy and outward orientation which have made India a significant player in the global economy. Between the 1980s and 2005, the dramatic adjustments in political, economic and social policies have transformed the Indian economy from the world's 50th largest, in nominal US dollars, to the 10th largest (Ahmed and Varshney, 2012). Further, Ahmed and Varshney (2012) state that 'when income is measured with regard to purchasing power parity, the Indian economy occupies 4th place, after the United States, Japan and China'. Concerns over India's ability to sustain an annual growth rate of 6 per cent have been replaced by prospects for increasing this growth rate to 8 per cent (Ahmed, 2007).

One important contributing factor in this phenomenal growth has been the involvement of Indian expatriates in the United States and elsewhere in the diaspora, who have played a crucial role in the process of India's global integration through the transfer of technology as well as social and financial remittances (Cheng 1999; Saxenian, 2006, 2008; Gold, 2007). Today, India is the top international remittance-receiving nation in the world. During the period 2000–2010, remittances to India increased from USD 13 billion to an estimated USD 55 billion, an increase of close to 300 per cent (Guha, 2011). One can claim that India's emergence as a top global innovator for high-tech products and services in the recent years has considerable role to play in the importation of the technological skills of overseas Indians, which is perceived as imperative to building India's national capacity. The Indian state wishes to maximize 'brain gain/circulation/return' and make effective use of foreign-trained Indian immigrants and nationals as a magnet for foreign and diasporic investments in knowledge-based industries (Kapur and Ramamurti, 2001).

In accordance with this reasoning, the Indian government's primary commitment during the 1980s was to achieve economic growth by establishing Indian businesses. The significant change during this period was the state's active participation in promoting the growth of industries like information technology. The changes in Indian economic policy during the 1980s and the state's pro-business attitude generated higher private investment and an enhanced role for the private sector in the Indian economy. These internal structural changes in the private sector set the stage for further reforms in state policies in the 1990s (Ray, 2011). The notable features of the reforms in the 1990s were in the area of India's external economic relations, including trade, foreign investment and financial relations. Starting in 1991 import quotas were lifted (albeit not fully until 2001), tariffs declined steadily, the currency was devalued, the foreign investment regime was liberalized and restrictions on external financial transactions were eased. These were significant macro-policy changes because they meant that the Indian state had entered into a new social contract with Indian businesses, putting its full weight behind them with the understanding that they had to become more competitive in the international arena.

This opening up of the Indian economy to the global markets presented a unique opportunity to the overseas Indian migrant community, and particularly to Indian migrants in the United States in the technology and financial sectors, to invest and establish business with India. Given their own professional success and resources, some members of the Indian migrant community in the United States felt compelled to actively participate in the economic growth and development of India. So by 2002, the combination of a recession in Silicon Valley, enormous difficulties with complicated and outdated immigration laws (Wadhwa and Salkever, 2012), and growing professional and entrepreneurial opportunities in India prompted for the first time a sustained interest among US educated Indians in STEM fields in returning to India (Saxenian, 2008). The 'brain drain' of earlier decades was reversed, creating the perfect 'brain gain/circulation' opportunity for Indian immigrants in the United States.

'Time to Go West...': Rationale for migration

Unlike resource-poor immigrants who have a clear motive for migration, the majority of the respondents in this study, particularly those who migrated in the 1980s and 1990s, did not perceive their move to the United States or elsewhere as being for permanent settlement. To 'return

home' after a period of time abroad was presumed as the next step. Thus, to understand their motives for migration it becomes necessary to examine the migrants' economic, social and human capital at the time of entry to the United States – their personal and familial ties and obligations and previous business/work affiliations – all of which provide information about the existence of various networks that enabled their migration to the United States and facilitated their return migration to India (Table 4.1).

Seeking education is the primary motive for migration, accounting for 50 per cent of the sample. In addition nearly 30 per cent of migrants relocated through a company transfer to the United States. A smaller proportion moved to the United States to re-unite with family members. The higher proportion of younger Indians choosing to migrate to the United States for advanced educational opportunities clearly reveals the extent of macro-structural influence at the individual level, explained by Cheng and Yang (1998) as the 'articulation of higher education between poor and rich countries since the 1970s'. One result of the global articulation of higher education has been higher levels of migration from poor to advanced countries by foreign students who want to pursue global business opportunities or be employable internationally. Indians are no exception to this phenomenon. A large number of respondents in the study had attended private English medium schools in India, and the desire for international mobility as young adults was a natural extension of the cosmopolitan character that was cultivated during their school and undergraduate college years in India. The aspiration for American higher education and personal ambition was also defined significantly by the economic class of their birth family. Being a member of the upper or middle class in India shaped their cultural and moral boundaries³ (Lamont et al., 1996). As a result the Indian migrant entrepreneurs had cultivated an ambition for

Table 4.1 Motives for emigration to the United States

Motive for emigration	Frequency	Per cent
Post-graduate training (second degree or qualification, masters degree, PhD)	21	50
Relocation by company transfer	12	29
Reunification with family	9	21
Total	42	100

Note: This table reflects all 42 respondents of the study.

Source: M. Ray, 2007 & 2011.

a particular lifestyle, which was tempered by an overarching awareness of the progressive internationalization of science and engineering. The perceived value of American educational opportunities in science was summarized by Deepak, a returnee entrepreneur above 50 years of age.

I came to the US for post-graduate education, because higher education in Engineering and in any field of Science is considered to be the best here than anywhere else. I wanted to think big. Studying in IISC⁴ makes you very hardworking. You have got to be that way in order to survive there, and it also opens opportunities for you to grow. But, in the US you learn things a little differently and at an international level. I learned to cultivate 'critical thinking' about issues. In fact, it becomes a second nature to think out of the box.

A factor of considerable importance in the context of facilitating the return decisions of migrant entrepreneurs in the United States is the strong peer bonding that had grown among different cohorts of migrants during their undergraduate years in the top-tier undergraduate colleges – like the Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs)⁵ and the professional four-year-degree colleges of State universities. This contributed towards developing migration networks, which assisted in their initial move to the United States. This college peer network was an influential source of motivation for the aspiring migrants, who were largely men. Indian graduate students in US universities encouraged their peers in India to migrate and established a sort of information system guiding their efforts for admission, graduate assistantships, housing and accommodation and so on. Here is Akash describing the persuasive and powerful influence of college peer networks on his desire to pursue mobility opportunities abroad soon after he completed his undergraduate studies in India.

After graduating from IIT, I felt a need to go to the US. It was a herd mentality. The peer pressure is very high. And, in IITs one gets so many signals from your seniors [including those who had migrated] and especially faculty while you are living in the IIT campus that you develop a mindset for migrating to the US for higher education. Parents too exert the same pressure. I think I would have got the same education in India that I got at Virginia Tech, but that would not have changed the way I had thought then. We are almost brainwashed to go to the US, after having done an undergraduate degree in engineering at IIT.

With the passage of time the migration networks and the peer bonding among migrants which had assisted in bringing them to the United States evolved into transnational business networks with the establishment of resourceful, ethnicized global organizations for Indian entrepreneurs (such as TiE) or alumni organizations (such as Pan IIT).

The 29 per cent of migrants who moved to the United States on behalf of the Indian multinational companies they worked for were sent for the purpose of expanding their companies' American operations. For the migrants themselves, the rationale behind their move from India was to advance their career goals and the ability to provide their children international education and exposure. Often the idea of relocation was floated by the migrants themselves and later supported by their peers and superiors in their company, both in India and their company's overseas operations. Therefore, the social capital embedded in personal relationships that originated among close friends in India and abroad was employed in forming these respondents' migratory network configurations.

Very few Indian women entrepreneurs in the sample migrated to the United States for higher education while single. These women stated that the motive for their migration was linked to their fiancés, who were in the United States at the time of their migration. Their decision to move to the United States was guided by the presence of their future husbands. So the general trend of 'migration through education' (Gu, 2012) played out differently for men and women. Of those migrants in the sample who moved for the purpose of family reunification, far more migrant women in this category entered the United States as spouses. Conventional gender roles certainly interfered with autonomous female migration, as Indian women are assumed to place their reproductive and household duties before the pursuit of higher education that could enable them to obtain a leadership role in workplace.

It is interesting to note that although it might appear that the move to the United States by the highly skilled immigrants in this sample was an independent and voluntary decision, it was in fact guided to a large extent by the social capital derived from the *strong*⁶ (Harvey, 2008) or *interpersonal ties*⁷ (Poros, 2001) of friendship embedded in their social migration networks. Their actions were directed by the normative content of trust and obligatory assistance of college peers and family members. Primarily, these norms of reciprocity, trust and identity had developed among the Indian migrants through their common experiences as undergraduate students at the same institutions in India.

To stay or not to stay: Rationale for return

The Indian migrant entrepreneurs in this research can be characterized according to the decades in which they migrated, with a distinct division between two periods: from 1965 until the end of the 1970s and from the early 1980s to the end of the 1990s. The migrants who moved during the former period were typically between 51 and 65 years old at the time of interview, had left India to improve their quality of life and had for the most part settled in the host country. Migrants in the later period were younger, with most being below 50 years of age, and included a large contingent of return migrants. The returnee entrepreneurs in particular perceived American higher education as a way to build their competitive advantage at an international level. For the returnee entrepreneurs, therefore, leaving for the United States and subsequently returning to India was an expected progression of life events for the advancement of their global entrepreneurship, as expressed by Kapil:

The word migration is strong in my case. I don't think I migrated. I traveled to the US for higher education. I worked for a couple of years so that I could build my financial capital and business network before returning home. I had always wanted to come back to India to start my business. No question about it.

Out of the entire sample of 42 migrants to the United States, 12 men and 5 women migrants decided to return to India between 1988 and 2002 (see Table 4.2). All but three returnee entrepreneurs had received graduate education in an American university. Six of the returnees were above the age of 50 at the time of interview, and 11 respondents were younger. The transnational business sectors of returnees covered a wide range of fields, including pharmaceuticals, international financial services, crafts and textiles, car sales, entertainment, publishing and building/construction. Only three returnees had retired from their long careers as salaried professionals in government and private sector jobs in the United States, contradicting much of the literature on return migration, which typifies returnees as retirees. Six of the respondents had lived in other countries besides the United States, five of them having travelled to these other countries before entering the United States. All the returnees were married and had children. Many of the children were born abroad. The returnees had spent between 5 and 20 years

Table 4.2 Profile of returnee transnational entrepreneurs in India

Name	Age	Sex	Class	Year of migration	Year of return to India	Destination and length of time overseas	Overseas education/employment	Current business sector in India
Gowri	<50	Female	Middle	1995	2000	USA 5	University/IT company	Bio-science
Rukmini	>50	Female	Upper	1983	1995	Germany 3 UK 2 USA 7	Housewife/university/multinational publishing company	Publishing services in scientific, medical and technical fields
Kavita	<50	Female	Middle	1990	2000	USA 10	University/pharmaceutical company	Pharmaceuticals
Radha	<50	Female	Middle	1989	1999	Japan 5 USA 5	Housewife/university/consultant	Textiles and craft
Simi	>50	Female	Middle	1977	1990	UK 3 USA 10	Housewife/furniture company/interior decoration	Craft and carpets
Kapil	<50	Male	Rich	1985	1997	USA 12	University/bank and IT company	International Finance
Sanjay	<50	Male	Middle	1988	2002	USA 14	University/multinational company	IT
Akash	<50	Male	Middle	1981	1992	USA 11	University/IT company	IT

Ravi	> 50	Male	Middle	1976	1995	Canada 8 USA 11	Multinational company/businessman/ social and environmental activist	Agro-industry
Suraj	> 50	Male	Middle	1972	1988	USA 16	University/ multinational agro company	Agro-industry
Amar	< 50	Male	Middle	1981	2001	USA 20	IT company/university/ IT entrepreneur	IT
Kunal	> 50	Male	Rich	1980	2000	UK 7 Switzerland 5 USA 8	University/IT company/ IT entrepreneur	IT
Madhav	< 50	Male	Rich	1990	2000	USA 10	University/family business	Real estate and construction
Raj	< 50	Male	Middle	1992	2000	USA 8	University/auto company	Auto industry
Shekar	< 50	Male	Middle	1991	2002	USA 11	University/global publishing company/ environmental activist	Author/technical publishing
Girish	< 50	Male	Middle	1995	2002	USA 7	University/ entertainment company	Advertising and event management
Deepak	> 50	Male	Rich	1986	2001	USA 12 Ireland 3	University professor/ bank/financial consultant	International finance

Source: Ray, 2011.

overseas – as graduate students, salaried professionals, or entrepreneurs and consultants – before making the decision to return to India.

Diverse and varied networks were employed by returnee entrepreneurs in the different business sectors for their preparation and return to India. For the eight returnee entrepreneurs in the technical sector, the significant contributions of the earlier cohort of pioneer migrants can be credited for facilitating the return to India. Indian migrants who had moved to the United States in the 1970s and founded technology companies in Silicon Valley and elsewhere in the United States had the foresight to establish global entrepreneurial networks – for example, TiE – which have proven to be an extremely valuable mechanism for global business in the technology sector for immigrant and returnee entrepreneurs in many countries, including India and the United States. Over the years, TiE has become a formidable platform to allow successful Indian immigrant entrepreneurs in the technology sector to share their resources, information and knowledge with other aspiring Indian entrepreneurs.⁸

At another level, technology entrepreneurs who immigrated in the 1970s and who had graduated from top-tier educational institutions in India made serious efforts and commitments to the growth and development of entrepreneurial networks involving alumni of their alma mater, such as the Pan IIT networks. I argue that the transnational alumni and global professional networks (Vertovec, 2002) served as a bridgehead in encouraging the return of migrants in the high-tech sector from the United States to India in the 1990s and afterwards, just as it had assisted them in migrating to the United States a decade or two before.

For the younger generation of returnee entrepreneurs, returning to India made perfect business sense when considering the economic factors in India that would support their enterprises: the availability of cheaper skilled labour, a booming Information Technology industry, access to financial capital and – above all – a stable, open, complementary macro-political and economic environment. This macro-structural combination was just right to allow them to compete in the tough global environment. The entrepreneurial atmosphere in India had changed significantly from the state-controlled socialism prior to the 1980s. The prevailing atmosphere of neo-liberalism enabled the growth of middle- and small-scale indigenous entrepreneurship among new and first-generation Indians who had no political access or capital but plenty of verve and ambition to challenge old monopolies owned by business families (Nilekani, 2009). Consequently, the perception among the returnee entrepreneurs and across Indian industries was that

they were in a position of unique strength in the international economy (Kamdar, 2007; Nilekani, 2009; Bardhan and Kroll, 2012). This perception was based on the success of domestic IT firms – Infosys, Wipro, Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) – in the international market, infra-structural investment in research and development, as well as outsourcing of software projects by established multinational firms like Hewlett-Packard, Intel, Microsoft, Oracle, Texas Instruments⁹ (Saxenian, 2012) and others because of the recession in the Silicon Valley around 2000.¹⁰ Return migrants' enthusiasm for the high quality of business and work opportunities and the promise of more career growth in India was expressed by Sanjay as follows:

This is the third wave for India. The first wave was to build software applications for back end functions, the second wave was all around BPO services [business process outsourcing], and the third wave is what is happening now where start ups and established players are building their products in India. Today we have all the leading software industries in the US as our clients, be it Google, Oracle, Yahoo etc. If I had remained in the US, I would have missed the bus.

Although a similar sentiment was shared by migrant entrepreneurs who were above the age of 50 years, they preferred to express it from afar. Many of the migrants in this age group felt abandoned and neglected by the Indian state, until the last few years. It is true that traditionally India had maintained a distance from the Indian diaspora and thwarted the gestures of goodwill and support for development from its emigrant community up to the time it embarked on the path of global integration in 1990 (Khanna, 2007).

Migrants' decision and act of return were preceded by the necessary 'preparation' phase. Several returnee migrants in IT or IT-related businesses functioned as business partners, consultants/advisors or angel investors¹¹ for technology firms in India prior to their return. In the role of business contact in the United States, these entrepreneurs provided Indian technology companies with critical contacts, information and cultural know-how that linked the companies to the United States and global economies. These kinds of transnational business connections expanded the returnee entrepreneurs' social networks and business relationships, which in turn made their decision to return easier. Many of the returnees in the technology field had cultivated enduring informal and formal ties with start-up Indian tech companies even while working at salaried jobs in the United States. For example, this is how

Kunal – who typifies others in the sample – described the role of pre-return connections and preparations in his decision to return to India.

Returning to India permanently was not a big decision for me. I had got married to a woman from Pune, who had mentioned at the time of our wedding she would want to live in India. I finished my doctoral studies and got a job almost immediately, then we had our first child...I had everything going for me actually...But, my wife felt very strongly about returning to India [but] I was ambivalent. But, I must say returning to India fitted well with my plans of starting a tech company of my own. So, when the opportunity came my way to join P... as a board member, I was delighted and grabbed it. P... was a fledging technology company of my buddies I had known at IIT. Linking up with my college friends made the transition to India easy...I had left for the US in 1980, as part of the herd from IIT. I had mentioned to my parents that I would return to India [in] 4–5 years. What changed was the number of years got extended, but I had not totally abandoned the idea of returning to India.

Therefore, return migrants in the tech sector were not simply moving in a vacuum between supply and demand situations in India and the United States. Their movements and entrepreneurial activities resulted from the collective actions of many others who shared a common cultural and social capital that can be historically and physically contextualized (Meyer, 2001).

On the other hand, the return entrepreneurs in the non-tech sectors – agro business, crafts, textiles, the auto industry, real estate and construction, advertising and entertainment – mainly used family business connections and ethnic, religious, trade and peer networks to facilitate their return to India. Most of the return migrants in this category belonged to medium and big business families in India, in which migration to the United States and return was perceived as a family strategy and a business plan for expanding the markets for their products and services. Their movement across countries and eventual return to India adheres to the theoretical concepts of the NELM (discussed earlier). Similar to the entrepreneurs in the tech sector, the men in this group had migrated to the United States in pursuit of higher education; the women, however, had emigrated as spouses. The women migrants later obtained American higher education degrees or had an apprenticeship with business firms in the United States, which emboldened them to start their own business enterprise. For the women returnees, migration and return were ‘tied moves’, reflecting both patriarchal and family

connections. Quite similar to Chamberlain's (1997) research focusing on West Indian (Barbadian) migration to Britain and back, in this case too, the family played a significant role as both the end goal and the means to achieve global migration and return.

For both men and women in this group their economic activities and personal behaviour were shaped and controlled by their respective ethno-religious business community in the Indian diaspora, such as the the Sindhi, Sikh and Gujarati diasporas. If the migrants in such diasporas did not meet their community's expectations, they would run the risks of loss of financial resources and close ties, and so on. Hence the decisions to return to India to some extent were dictated by the solidarity and expectations of their family business and community ties upon the occurrence of some significant event, like the death of a family member or the expansion and diversification of the family business. Consequently, return migrants in non-tech sectors relocated with their families close to the cities and regions where their family business was situated, for example, in Varanasi, Lucknow, Kolkata and Bombay. Respondents Simi, Radha and Suraj relocated because the physical sites for their business in India were places of traditional skill and craft, or contained natural resources that was required for preserving and nurturing their consumer goods. These entrepreneurs conceived of their location as the locus from which global networks originated. In the words of one of them:

My parents and my team of workers with whom I set up this business were located in Y... I have never dreamt of taking my business anywhere else. If I had to set up my business in any other city in India I would have faced major competition. Besides, I am close to all the villages where I work, and live close enough to factories where all the stuff [hand crafted textiles and crafts] that I sell is made. Why on earth should I go elsewhere?

While available peer, community and family business networks were essential, there were other decisive factors the returnee entrepreneurs took into consideration in coming to the decision to return to India. The return migrants' new ways of imagining migration and return and future work were guided as much by their own personal life-stage transition issues, nostalgia for the Indian way of life and feelings of nationalism as by the possibility of taking advantage of business opportunities in India, thanks to support from their well-established entrepreneurial networks, the enabling macro-business environment in India and their personal endowment of human and social capital. So, for the return migrant

entrepreneurs it was the convergence of a set of factors at the most opportune time that prompted their decision to return.

Kavita, a woman returnee entrepreneur, expressed that her decision to return with her family was motivated as much by her desire to give her children an Indian education and knowledge of Indian culture and languages as well as to care for her elderly parents as by career considerations.

My daughter was young when we decided it was time we moved back to India. That is why we had not bought any property in the US, nor had any investment. All our money was in stocks. If I had waited until my child went to middle or high school it would be difficult for her to adjust to Indian schools. It's a combination of reasons which prompts you to decide where you want to do your business, so it wasn't just one reason.

It is evident that for some returnees having children abroad did not necessarily prevent return migration, but those with children in their teens or older were obviously hesitant to move back to India. Indian migrants who had left India in the mid- or late 1970s often expressed that it would be an uphill battle for their older children to fit into Indian society and the education system. So, by the time other circumstances might have induced them to return to India, it was too late.

Some returnees indicated that their feelings about distance and their stage of life played a role in their decision to return to India. For return migrants of both genders, territorial meanings, identification and attachment proved to be a powerful incentive to live in India. They perceived their act of return as a chance to fulfil their nationalistic and other dreams, as conveyed by Kunal, a senior returnee who had lived overseas for 20 years in the United Kingdom, Switzerland and the United States, and who had started his transnational business in the United States in 1985, before deciding to return to India permanently in 2000.

Very soon after graduating with a PhD in Economics, I had a job and within the next two to three years I had everything going for me. So, my thoughts of making an impact on India came back. Thankfully, this was the time when the IT revolution was taking off in India. So with the coming of Information Technology age, I felt I got the opportunity for what I had long since wanted to do that is to integrate work with other aspects of life – a holistic approach to living. In order to make the broadest impact I settled on doing what one would consider low tech work. It allowed me to create

plenty of jobs in those segments of the population which was unemployable in India at that time.

The age of the migrants in the context of life-course transitions is significant, as it was factored in their decision-making about returning to India. Most of the return migrants, particularly those younger than 50, felt strongly that they were at a stage in life that entailed unique relationships and roles, such as caring for elderly parents or being a parent, that went along with certain responsibilities that could be best fulfilled in India. Although family roles and responsibilities are not the only type of relationships that were important for the returnee entrepreneurs, they did assume a prominent place in the definition of this stage in their individual lives (Elder 1998; White and Klein, 2002; Elder, Johnson and Crosnoe, 2003). When analysed from a life-course perspective (Lauer and Wong, 2010), the historically unique cultural and contextual forces that the migrants interacted with, such as patriotism and parenthood, set the trajectory of this life stage.

Conclusion

In this research, using the case of returnee transnational entrepreneurs migrating from the United States back to India, I provide evidence that return migration is a diverse and a complex process, where multiple social, economic and cultural factors come into play both in emigration from India and in returning to the home country. I emphasize how migratory and global entrepreneurial, college alumni and family networks functioned as a source of social capital which facilitated the entry of highly skilled Indian migrants to the United States and later the return of these migrants to India. However, underlying the general pattern of migration, there were social and cultural differences between subgroups of migrants from different business sectors, which had a bearing on migrants' return decisions. In addition, the age and gender of the returnees weighed appreciably in their considerations. Further, it is obvious that macroeconomic changes in India altered the factors that had motivated migrants to leave their home country, often resulting in a shorter duration of stay overseas compared to migrants who had emigrated before 1980.

The findings from this study suggest a new understanding of the relationship between emigrant-sending and immigrant-receiving countries in this current moment of capitalism. In doing so, the chapter shifts the debate beyond the macro push-and-pull factors in different countries

to micro-meso level dynamics as major explanatory factors of what actually motivates migration and return decisions.

Notes

1. National Association of Software and Services Companies. As of 2008 it had a membership of 1,300 Indian and multinational companies, who have a broad presence in India in the businesses of software development, software services, software products, consulting services, business process outsourcing (BPO) services, e-commerce and web services, engineering services, off shoring, animation and gaming.
2. A. Kohli, 'State, Business, and Economic Growth in India', *Studies in Comparative International Development* 42, no. 1–2 (2007): 87–114, on 89, defines an 'interventionist state' to be one that prioritizes economic growth as a state goal and that therefore ruthlessly supports capitalists, represses labour, mobilizes economic nationalism to act as a social glue and channels firm activities to produce both for protected domestic markets and for exports.
3. M. Lamont et al., 'Cultural and Moral Boundaries in the United States: Structural Position, Geographic Location, and Lifestyle Explanations', *Poetics* 24 (1996), on 34, explain that 'cultural boundaries [are] based on self-actualization (including intellectual curiosity), manners, tastes, education, and appreciation of high culture. Those who feel superior towards people who are less culturally sophisticated than themselves are said to draw cultural boundaries.' Similarly, moral boundaries are drawn on the basis of moral character. Character is comprised of qualities such as honesty, work ethic, personal integrity, sexuality, religiosity and consideration for others.
4. IISc is the Indian Institute of Science, a premier institution of higher education and scientific research in India.
5. These are a group of autonomous public institutes of higher education in engineering. There are seven IITs at present.
6. W.S. Harvey, 'Strong or Weak Ties? British and Indian Expatriate Scientists Finding Jobs in Boston,' *Global Networks* 8, no. 4 (2008), on 456–457, defines 'strong ties' as relationships with close friends, family members, spouses, close office/work colleagues, school or college mates or peers, whereas 'weak ties' are relationships with business associates from other companies, acquaintances or people who are less well known to the individual.
7. M.V. Poros, 'The Role of Migrant Networks in Linking Local Labor Markets: The Case of Asian Indian Migration to New York and London', *Global Networks* 1, no.3 (2001), on 245, distinguishes between interpersonal and organizational ties. Interpersonal ties are social relationships with family members, relatives and friends. Organizational ties are the mediating structures of firm/organization/school networks, which include social relationships with colleagues, fellow alumni, supervisors and so on. Sometimes interpersonal ties of family and friendship exist within organizations.
8. The founding members of TiE included three of the most successful older Indian entrepreneurs in Silicon Valley: Suhas Patil, former MIT professor and founder of Cirrus Logic; Prabhu Goel, founder of Gateway Design

- Automation; and Kanwal Rekhi, founder of Exelan, which merged with Novell. At present, TiE has 53 chapters in 12 countries spread across five continents. Source: TiE.
9. Saxenian (2006), *The New Argonauts*, on 274–287, states that in the 1980s and 1990s a small but significant cohort of US-educated Indian engineers (NRIs) played a critical role in convincing the management of their respective US corporations that India was the best location for their software development centres and encouraged the use of Indian firms as outsourcing partners. They also initiated an ongoing dialogue with Indian policy makers and laid the foundation for cooperation between Indian government officials and the successive generation of American multinationals.
 10. The economic recession in the early 2000s was felt mostly in Western countries, and affected the United States mostly in 2002 and 2003. This sequence of events is also commonly known as the IT boom of the 1990s followed by the IT bust of 2000, when many service jobs were outsourced to India.
 11. An angel investor is an affluent individual who provides capital for a business start-up, usually in exchange for ownership equity.

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